People with Cognitive Disabilities

- **Say:**
  - My name is…. I'm here to help you, not hurt you.
  - I am a … (*name your job*)
  - I am here because … (*explain the situation)*
  - I look different than my picture on my badge because … (*for example, if you are wearing protective equipment)*
- **Show:**
  - Your picture identification badge (*as you say the above).*
  - That you are calm and competent.
- **Give:**
  - Extra time for the person to process what you are saying and to respond.
  - Respect for the dignity of the person as an equal and as an adult (*example: speak directly to the person).*
  - If needed, offer an arm to the person to hold as they walk, or an elbow for balance.
  - If possible, quiet time to rest (*as possible, to lower stress and fatigue).*

- **Use:**
  - Short sentences.
  - Simple, concrete words.
  - Accurate, honest information.
  - Pictures and objects to illustrate your words. Point to your ID picture as you say who you are, point to any protective equipment as you speak about it.
- **Predict:**
  - What will happen (*simply and concretely)?*
  - When events will happen (*tie to common events in addition to numbers and time, for example, "By lunch time…" "By the time the sun goes down…").*
  - How long this will last – when things will return to normal (*if you know).*
  - When the person can contact or rejoin loved ones (*for example: calls to family, re-uniting pets)*

- **Ask for/Look for:**
  - An identification bracelet with special health information.
  - Essential equipment and supplies (*for example: wheelchair, walker, oxygen, batteries, communication devices [head pointers, alphabet boards, speech synthesizers, etc.])*
  - Medication
  - Mobility aids (*for example, assistance or service animal)*
  - Special health instructions (*for example: allergies).*
  - Special communication information (*for example, is the person using sign language)?*
  - Contact information.
  - Signs of stress and/or confusion (*for example, the person might say he or she is stressed, look confused, withdraw or start rubbing their hands together).*
  - Conditions that people might misinterpret (*for example, someone might mistake Cerebral Palsy for drunkenness).*
- **Repeat:**
  - Reassurances (*for example, "You may feel afraid. That's ok. We're safe now.")*

- Encouragement (*for example, "Thanks for moving fast. You are doing great. Other people can look at you and know what to do").*
- Frequent updates on what's happening and what will happen next. Refer to what you predicted will happen, for example: "Just like I said before, we're getting into my car now. We'll go to… now".

- **Reduce:**
  - Distractions. For example: lower volume of radio, use flashing lights on vehicle only when necessary.

- **Explain:**
  - Any written material (*including signs)* in everyday language.
  - Public address system announcements in simple language.

- **Share:**
  - The information you've learned about the person with other workers who'll be assisting the person.